

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 106

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Section Title(S): C. Speech • D. Food/Work

c. Speech

The bride's respectful conduct towards her F-in-l is clearly defined in speech avoidance. She must not talk with her HF at all is the first generalized statement made. To communicate with him, she should use a go-between, either her HM or a child. When after a r/r she is allowed to speak with her HF, she must take care not to approach him too closely, nor to speak aloud in his presence. Normally, when a person is called, he responds with *We*, but a newly married woman remains mute, indicating by her attitude and attention that she is listening. She avoids any talk that may be considered disrespectful. Such submissiveness is extended to all in-laws: she may not joke with any of them except her HSis, her Sis-in-l. If she violates the rule she is fined a goat (130).

[606](#)
[Parents-In-Law And Children-In-Law](#)

[607](#)
[Siblings-In-Law](#)

[688](#)
[Religious Offenses](#)

[784](#)
[Avoidance And Taboo](#)

A bride does not use the pers/n of her H's male agnatic kinsmen and avoids the roots of their names. The rule is not only observed with regard to HF, HFBrS, HBrS but extends to HM, HFWis and HeSi as well. The sanction is compensatory: a goat. When women use substitute words for the names of any of their in-laws, they declare this to be a case of *uBaba*, of honouring their HF.

[551](#)
[Personal Names](#)

[688](#)
[Religious Offenses](#)

[784](#)
[Avoidance And Taboo](#)

Among the actions avoided by a yoWi are swearing at people and using vulgar language in her H's homestead. She may not use the names of her affines in

[195](#)
[Sociolinguistics](#)

asseveration, but continues to use her F's or Br's pers/ns, and other names of her patriliney.

551
Personal Names

784
Avoidance And Taboo

It is considered most reprehensible for a yoWi to point her finger at an in-law. It reveals callous disregard of her position among her affines; she is fined a goat. No yoWi may stand in the presence of older members of her H's family. She goes down on her knees when entering her HF's hut. A woman may not eat standing. The violation angers her HF and the H's ancestors. (374) admits: Nothing happens, there is no punishment for it. But it is a thoroughly bad action. Munching food outside in the yard is viewed in the same light: *umLobokazi kaDli emZini kaNinazala* (Bryant: 1949: 221).

264
Eating

576
Etiquette

602
Kin Relationships

784
Avoidance And Taboo

d. Food/Work

With regard to the production and consumption of food, a bride's avoidances are sanctioned by reference to her in-laws and her HF in particular. The bride may not carry firewood and water across her H's homestead. The Chn of the home, even the HM, do it for her. When a bride fetches water 'the pot goes out first', i.e., a small girl takes it out for her to the gate. There the bride picks it up and deposits it full at the same spot, where the small carrier takes it over again. The same is done with firewood. A bride who breaks this rule is said to be a 'fool' for she is expected to know custom. At this stage she does not cook yet nor touch ash. A bride cannot yet handle beer. She does not go near the place where the men of the homestead cook meat. She does not work in the fields, where her HF is buried, nor does she eat the crops of such fields.

606
Parents-In-Law And
Children-In-Law

607
Siblings-In-Law

784
Avoidance And Taboo

A yoWi does not eat food in the presence of her in-laws until she is ritually released (Krige: 30). Informants are definite that this is a HI custom, but cannot suggest what happens if it is violated. It is never broken, they say, for girls are taught this by their Ms at home. (347) adds: "A bride may not see me — her HF — eat. If she enters my hut while I am eating, I stop chewing. When she notices this she withdraws. If she is aware that I am eating in a hut, it is respectful for her (HI) not to walk past its door." No bride eats the food left over by her HF.

264
Eating

606
Parents-In-Law And
Children-In-Law

784
Avoidance And Taboo

867
Transmission Of
Cultural Norms

A yoWi avoids the meat of her H's homestead. This avoidance is removed at the earliest opportunity. The rule against a bride working with cattle is more elaborate and tenacious, but exceptions are allowed right from the beginning; she may for instance, take the calves to their special pen immediately after

231
Domesticated Animals

262

her wedding, if there are no boys available. A young Wi may not eat the SM of her H (=HF)'s homestead. This is the most characteristic avoidance of a bride.

Diet

606
Parents-In-Law And
Children-In-Law

784
Avoidance And Taboo

The avoidance of meat, cattle and milk may be interconnected. Various Zulu explanations suggest this. (372) says: "When a bride avoids (HI) her H's SM, pen and calabashes, she respects (HI) the whole homestead including inmates and ancestors through these objects. She must avoid the cattle for they have been received from the ancestors, the H's ancestors." (413) is asked why a bride cannot eat SM at her H's. A bride hearing this laughs, and (413) hesitates with his answer. Q: Would there be any indications to show if she ate SM in secret? Ans.: Yes, an illness caused by the ancestors would occur. The residents will go to the diviner, who  107 reveals that it is caused by the ancestors. As soon as this diagnosis has been made, the patient recovers. No sacrifice is necessary, nor is a confession by the bride called for — she would feel too ashamed (*amaHloni*) to make it; the diagnosis suffices. Her H might scold her, for she broke the avoidance. A diviner never makes a wrong guess, for if the woman had not eaten SM, no sickness would have come. In (413)'s opinion nothing happens to the cattle themselves if the bride ate SM. (347) at first did not see any connection between the avoidance by a son of his F's SM spoon and a yoWi's avoidance of her H's SM. But when I explained that the So may not handle his F's SM spoon because it is a symbol of his authority over the son and indeed the whole family, he agreed that a yoWi might not be allowed to eat the home's SM, since she has not been authorized to do so by her H or HF.

231
Domesticated Animals

262
Diet

753
Theory Of Disease

755
Magical And Mental
Therapy

769
Cult Of The Dead

784
Avoidance And Taboo

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